GM Guide

The run “Trial by Fire” step by step · Seattle 2080 · Meridian Spire

before the session **AT A GLANCE**

What is really going on

A one-shot for 3–4 players, three to four hours, Seattle 2080. The crew is to steal a briefcase from a private vault level during a gala. What they do not know: the vault belongs to the employer.

SEE ALSO Plan Section: 2D

The job

PUBLIC

- Retrieve a black briefcase from the vault below the penthouse during the gala
- Hand the case over **unopened**, take **nothing** else
- Do not harm Dr. Amara Venn, avoid deaths
- Access: physical vault keycard + Venn’s eye scan

The truth

GM ONLY

- Penthouse, vault, collection and case belong to the dragon **Veyrath**
- Mr. Johnson works for Veyrath; the run is a **trial by fire**
- No rival dragon, no other owner, no hidden twist behind it
- Veyrath neither intervenes nor rescues

What is being tested

THE YARDSTICK

- Understanding orders and taking them seriously
- Solving unusual problems independently
- Not escalating at once under pressure
- Not stealing everything just because they can
- Working as a team

TIMETABLE FOR 3–4 HOURS

SECTION	GUIDE
Character choice + short Shadowrun/RitS intro	15–25 min
Meeting Mr. Johnson	10–15 min
Gather information + plan	10–20 min
Entry and party	45–70 min
Vault level	45–70 min
Escape + reveal	20–35 min
Buffer	20–30 min

If characters were chosen in advance, far more time remains for the mission itself. The chapters on the left follow the flow at the table; tick them off as you go. The alert clock and the payoff calculator accompany you through the whole run.

GUIDELINES

- No playbook and no single action is mandatory.
- Keycard and eye scan are problems, not prescribed puzzles.
- Veyrath tests the crew but never fudges a dice result and never becomes a combat encounter.
- A full alert is escalation, not automatic failure. Consequences create new situations.
- Competent runners need no roll for routine. Good ideas may bypass prepared scenes.
- If the runners earn the truth about the employer, tell them.
- For 3–4 hours: playability before completeness.

KEY PEOPLE



Mr. Johnson

Variant A · seasoned fixer, the face of the job

ELF | DECADES IN THE BUSINESS | TABLET & AR GLASSES

A calm professional who keeps Veyrath's contacts into the shadows. He arrives early, is already seated in the privacy booth when the crew shows up, and holds a glass tablet he barely glances at during the whole conversation: whatever he needs to know, his rimless AR glasses show him. No threats, no theatre. Johnson keeps agreements and expects the same.

LOOK

- Older elf, silver-grey hair combed back and tied at the nape, fine lines around the eyes
- Rimless AR glasses, a thin cable running to his ear; glass tablet
- Charcoal-grey tailored suit, no insignia
- Polite, factual, never hurried
- Actually finishes his soykaf

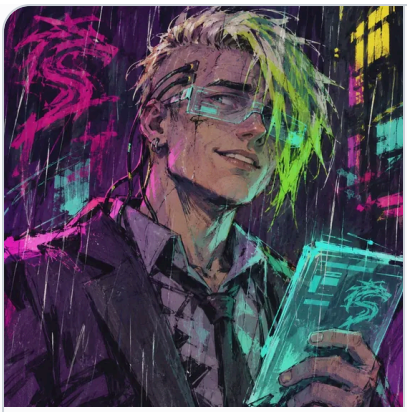
AT THE TABLE

- States "unopened" matter-of-factly as one condition among several, without stressing it.
- Does not haggle over agreed terms after the run.
- Answers questions about his client with "My client values discretion."

GM ONLY

Works directly for Veyrath and knows the run is a trial. He does not reveal it, but he does not lie clumsily either: anyone watching closely notices that he studies the crew like applicants.

"The case is handed over closed. Nothing else in that room interests my client, and it should not interest you either."



Mr. Johnson

Variant B · rookie fixer who is being tested too

HUMAN | EARLY 20S | DATAJACKS & TABLET

Veyrath's newest go-between, barely older than the youngest runners at the table and never before in charge of a job this size. He has prepared thoroughly, far too thoroughly: he reads the conditions off his tablet, has memorised the pay range, and has a prepared answer for every question, until one comes he did not expect. He badly wants to look professional and is more likeable than he would like to be.

LOOK

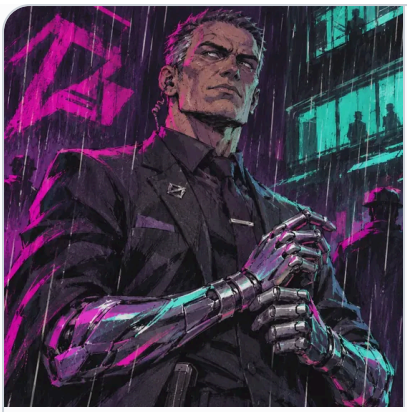
- Bleached hair with a neon-green streak over one eye, one side cut short
- Datajacks at both temples, cables running into his collar; AR glasses
- Suit a touch too sharp, tie loosened; a tablet with a cracked edge
- Smiles too often, glances at the tablet too often

AT THE TABLE

- The contract conditions stay exactly the same; only the tone changes.
- Under hard haggling he starts to flounder and searches his tablet for an answer. He still gives no more than the intended range.
- Under pressure he lets slip one detail too many, such as how well his client knows the tower. A good consequence that does not spoil the reveal.
- Treat him fairly and you gain a contact who rises with Veyrath.

> **GM ONLY**
> Knows the run is a trial for the crew, but not that Veyrath is grading him as well: how he runs the briefing, whether he keeps the conditions and whether he pays the crew cleanly afterwards. If the crew fails, so does he. He reveals nothing, but he is a bad liar, and anyone watching closely notices he is at least as nervous as the runners.

"Right. Conditions. The case stays shut, take nothing else, and nobody touches Dr. Venn. That is ... not negotiable. Yes. Not negotiable."



Dorian Kade

Variant A · head of security for the gala, knows the way to the keycard

HUMAN | CYBERARMS | AUGMENTED REFLEXES

Runs security for the evening and wants one thing above all: no visible incident in front of the VIPs. Kade is polite, calm and extremely attentive. He does not carry the vault keycard himself, but knows exactly where it sits in the black key box in the event office and how a legitimate withdrawal is logged. He authorises the release or assigns someone to do so.

LOOK

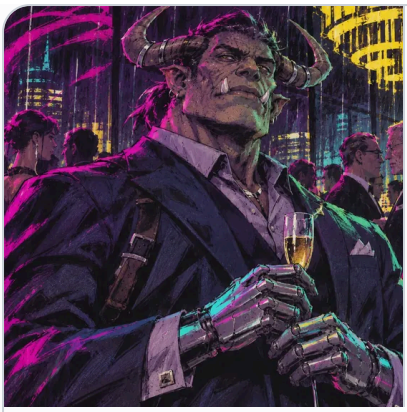
- Elegant dark tailored suit over two flawlessly chromed cyberarms
- Small, almost imperceptible twitches in hands, shoulders and gaze
- Discreetly armed with a pistol

AT THE TABLE

- Source of information, obstacle or opportunity, never a mandatory waypoint.
- Politely asks for identification instead of threatening.
- Reacts to alert: on suspicion he asks questions, on active alarm he keeps guests away from endangered areas.

> **GM ONLY**
> Suspects nothing of the test. Anyone who gives him a plausible explanation can lower alert; anyone who deceives him gains an opponent with very fast reflexes.

“I have nobody matching your description on the list. That need not mean anything. Help me clear it up before someone else does.”



Dorian Kade

Variant B · troll head of security who fits into high society

TROLL | CYBERARMS | AUGMENTED REFLEXES

Runs security for the evening and wants one thing above all: no visible incident in front of the VIPs. Trolls and penthouse galas do not really go together, yet Kade fits right in: he knows the guests' names, the etiquette and the wine list, moves surprisingly quietly through the crowd and speaks more softly than most humans in the room. He is still dangerous, and everyone can see it. Like variant A he does not carry the vault keycard himself, but knows exactly where it sits in the black key box in the event office and how a legitimate withdrawal is logged.

LOOK

- Nearly 2.60 m, broad shoulders, midnight-blue suit tailored to troll size, flawlessly cut
- Curved, polished horns with thin platinum rings; well-kept tusks
- Two chromed cyberarms built specially for him; the cufflinks still sit perfectly
- Small twitches in hands and gaze betray augmented reflexes
- A pistol in a shoulder holster that looks almost dainty in his hand

AT THE TABLE

- Same role as variant A: source of information, obstacle or opportunity, never a mandatory waypoint.
- Polite, well-spoken, a little old-fashioned. Anyone who takes him for mere muscle is corrected with a smile.
- His presence alone is a consequence: wherever he stands, the room goes quiet and runners find it harder to explain themselves.
- If it comes to violence, he is faster than a troll has any right to be.

> **GM ONLY**
> Suspects nothing of the test. He worked hard for his place in this world and notices at once when someone plays on prejudice against him. Anyone who treats him with respect and gives him a plausible explanation can lower alert; anyone who deceives him gains an opponent with troll strength and very fast reflexes.

"Please, stay seated. I won't join you, the chairs here aren't built for me. But I would like your name. And then the real one."



Dr. Amara Venn

Head curator of Vesperline Collections · the biometric key

ORK | MID-40S | LEFT EYE = BIOMETRICS

Art historian and security curator. She is responsible for selection, provenance and the physical handover of the most valuable pieces, and one of the few people whose eye scan the vault accepts. Venn considers most guests people with too much money and too little understanding of art; genuine interest in a piece wins her attention at once. She wants to end the evening without incident and go home.

LOOK

- Tall, slim, very upright posture, shaved head
- Polished silver caps on both tusks
- Left eye amber and natural; right eye a black cybereye without an iris
- Dark green, severely cut evening suit, golden feather brooch

AT THE TABLE

- Mostly in the gallery; occasionally retreats to the winter garden.
- Can register guests for a private viewing and escort them to the airlock.
- Does not have the vault keycard and cannot open the vault alone.
- Must not be harmed, per the contract. Abduction is possible but conspicuous.

> **GM ONLY**
> Knows nothing of the trial. Her suspicion is a good consequence: she asks follow-up questions, calls Kade over, or announces her departure when the party drags on.

“You are actually looking at the piece, not the price tag. That is rare tonight. Come, let me show you why it hangs here.”



Veyrath

Ambitious young dragon · owner and true employer

DRAGON | CLIMBER | NOT AN ANTAGONIST

A young dragon of great ambition: far behind the great dragons in age and standing, but determined to keep rising in the hierarchy of the Sixth World. He does not fear the old dragons in the least; he considers them sluggish and stuck in their ancient feuds, and means to gain ground where they are not looking. He acts through intermediaries, not out of shyness, but because he only shows his moves once they are in place. The penthouse, vault, collection and briefcase are his; he stands behind Vesperline Collections and several shell companies. Veyrath regards runners as potentially valuable specialists and is looking for a small crew for later tasks meant to carry him further up: tools that do not already belong to another dragon. What interests him is reliability when greed, fear and improvisation collide.

LOOK

- Appears only at the reveal: a vast shadow, wings in the rain
- Speaks directly into the runners' minds
- Stays out of reach, blocks nothing, never attacks

AT THE TABLE

- Neither rescues nor hinders the crew. The building is the obstacle, not him.
- Judges at the end: discipline, creativity, teamwork, control of escalation.
- Values his property above metahuman life. That is deliberately uncomfortable.
- Is never a combat encounter. If someone shoots at him, he ends the contact.

> **GM ONLY**
> Has allowed a difficult but realistically exploitable weakness in event mode for this one night. Collection, guests, staff and security are real. If the crew pulls off exceptional research, they may learn this beforehand; the reveal then becomes confirmation.

"Call me Veyrath. The tower is mine. The vault is mine. And so is the case you have just stolen."

15–25 min **STEP 1**

Getting started at the table

Choose characters, then cover world and rules in a few minutes.
Nobody needs more before the first roll.

SEE ALSO Cheat sheet Core rules | Cheat sheet Running rolls | Runner dossiers | Sheets

SHADOWRUN IN FIVE SENTENCES

Seattle 2080 is a city of vast corporations, extreme inequality, ubiquitous connectivity and real magic. Humans and metahumans live among AR advertising, cyberware, drones, spirits and privatised security. **Shadowrunners** do unofficial jobs for people who do not want to be linked to a deed; that is why the employer is called **Mr. Johnson**.

- You are competent professional criminals and may dare risky things.
- The world is full of tech, Matrix and magic.
- A good plan helps, but nobody plans every eventuality in advance.
- When something goes wrong, a new complication arises instead of game over.

RITS IN FIVE MINUTES

Action roll

FICTION FIRST

First the player describes what their runner does and wants. Only when something dangerous is at stake do you roll: as many d6 as the action rating, the highest counts.

- **6** full success · **4/5** success with a consequence · **1–3** bad plus consequence
- Several 6s: critical
- Settle beforehand: **position** (controlled / risky / desperate) and **effect** (limited / standard / great)
- Actions are not knowledge skills; they follow what the character actually does

Edge & flashbacks

RESERVE AND PREPARATION

- **2 edge**: push yourself, +1d or more effect
- **1 edge**: assist a teammate, +1d
- **Resistance roll** softens a consequence; it always works, the roll sets the edge cost
- **Flashback**: mid-run, explain what you had prepared. The more elaborate, the more edge

PLAN AND ENGAGEMENT

The group only picks a rough plan and names the required detail. Then comes the **engagement roll**, and you cut straight to the first interesting situation.

`Assault · point of attack` `Deception · method` `Social · connection`
`Stealth · entry point` `Supernatural · power / method` `Transport · route & means`

> **IMPORTANT**
> Do not let the group spend an hour planning around hypothetical security measures. Once plan and detail are set, the run begins. Everything else is a flashback.

10–15 min STEP 2

Meeting Mr. Johnson

Calm, professional, no trap. The job is stated clearly, the conditions named plainly. This is where you set the yardstick the crew will later be measured against.

SEE ALSO Johnson (A) Johnson (B)

RECOMMENDED VENUE: “RAINCHECK”

A 24-hour soykaf diner on a middle floor of a mixed-use high-rise. Rain runs in broad sheets down the panoramic windows. Most tables are empty; delivery drones wait outside on a charging rail. Johnson is already seated in a semi-transparent privacy booth, charcoal tailored suit, rimless AR glasses, a glass tablet in front of him and a steaming soykaf beside it.

TWO JOHNSONS TO CHOOSE FROM

Under “Key people” there are two variants: the seasoned elven professional who barely needs his tablet (as described here) and a young rookie fixer with datajacks who clings to his tablet and whom Veyrath is testing too. Job, conditions and pay are the same either way; the rookie makes the briefing looser and gives the crew someone to root for.

Late ferry

ALTERNATIVE

Johnson boards at a stop, sits next to the crew for ten minutes and vanishes into the crowd at the next landing.

Parking deck above the clouds

ALTERNATIVE

An almost empty automated car park in the upper floors of an office tower. Wind and rain whip through open sides while autonomous vehicles roll in and out without a word.

Private Matrix lounge

ALTERNATIVE

A rented virtual meeting room. For a first Shadowrun evening the physical option is better: the players get to know the real Sixth World first.

THE BRIEFING

The job

IN JOHNSON’S WORDS

During tonight’s gala, retrieve a specific briefcase from the private vault beneath the penthouse of the Meridian Spire. Johnson provides a current photo of Dr. Venn and an exact description of the case.

Conditions

THE CONTRACT

- The case is handed over **unopened**.
- **Nothing else** is taken from the vault.
- Dr. Amara Venn is **not harmed**.
- No wetwork. Avoidable deaths are expressly unwanted.
- How the crew proceeds is up to them.

Known access factors

TWO KEYS

1. A physical vault keycard, somewhere in the penthouse during the gala.
2. The biometric eye scan of Dr. Amara Venn.

Pay

RECOMMENDED 6 NUYEN

A serious, professional run. 4 nuyen for a lighter tutorial feel, 8 only if the briefing should already hint at an exceptionally rich employer. Paid on handover per contract; Johnson does not haggle afterwards.

DO NOT FORESHADOW

Johnson names “unopened” plainly as one condition among several and does not stress the word. The hidden tamper protection is not hinted at in the briefing. Anyone who examines the case later on their own initiative can find clues.

What Johnson does not say

- That penthouse, vault and case belong to Veyrath himself.
- That Veyrath is the true employer behind him.
- That the job is a test.
- That the security configuration deliberately leaves a chance.

If the runners earn this information through credible research, do not hold it back artificially.

10–20 min STEP 3

Gather information

One or two targeted questions per player are enough. The group only needs enough to settle plan and detail.

SEE ALSO Plan Section: 2D | Cheat sheet Matrix, tech & alert | Dr. Venn | Kade (A)

? When is security weakest?

During **event mode**. Between midnight and the end of the gala both access factors are on site at the same time. Afterwards the keycard leaves the building again and the vault goes into a stricter lockdown.

? Where is the keycard?

In the service area there is a small, non-public **event office** where sensitive event equipment is kept during the gala.

On a particularly good result: the card sits there in a black key box; withdrawal and return are logged.

? How do I get close to Dr. Venn?

Venn mostly stays near the exhibited pieces and readily explains details to genuinely interested guests. She occasionally withdraws to a quieter **winter garden** to escape the small talk.

? What gear stands out?

Guests may carry light personal gear. Big weapons, heavy armour and obvious operational equipment are hardly plausible in the glass elevator and become a problem at reception. **Service staff** can bring far bulkier crates and tools.

? Is there an alternative way in?

An automated maintenance system runs along the outer façade with a small cleaning and inspection gondola. It can dock at a technical airlock near the penthouse.

? What awaits us below the penthouse?

The vault level is normally unmanned. It works with sensors, airlocks and autonomous security drones.

? What kind of building is this?

The ownership structure ends behind several opaque holdings. Vesperline Collections is only the visible management.

On exceptional research: behind the structure stands the dragon **Veyrath**, and the penthouse with its vault is his. The later reveal still works: it turns from twist into confirmation that a dragon is testing the crew by having them break into his own property.

PACING LEVER

If the group debates too long, ask only: which plan? which detail? which load? Then engagement roll and cut.

transition **STEP 4**

Plan, engagement and entry

Once plan and detail are set, the engagement roll follows and you cut to the first serious situation. These approaches are offers, not solutions.

SEE ALSO Plan Section: 2D · Plan Parking garage: 2D · 3D · Plan Level 111: 2D · 3D · Cheat sheet Which action?

PLAN	POSSIBLE DETAIL
Social	A genuine invitation through a contact
Deception	Catering crew with a forged shift assignment
Stealth	Maintenance airlock on the façade
Transport	Jump from an aircraft onto the roof
Supernatural	A concrete magical method of the runners
Assault	A technical access point the crew takes by force

A bad engagement does not mean the planning was stupid. It only means the first situation is already dangerous.

POSSIBLE APPROACHES

As guests via the glass elevator

SOCIAL · DECEPTION

+ Little attention once inside
+ Direct contact with Dr. Venn
+ Ideal for observation and deception
– Invitation and identity must be plausible
– Bulky gear stands out
– The elevator logs arrivals

Copied an invitation, got a name onto the guest list, stashed a weapon in the penthouse beforehand.

As staff via garage and freight elevator

DECEPTION · STEALTH

+ Tools, crates and gear are plausible
+ Direct access to the service area and the keycard
– Staff are separated by function and location
– Unknown names stand out on rosters
– Being in the wrong area looks suspicious fast

Forged work ID, manipulated shift list, real uniform, delivery order.

Jump onto the roof

TRANSPORT · ASSAULT

+ Hardly any social prerequisites
+ Lots of gear possible
+ Spectacular for physical runners
– Weather, wind, altitude
– Visible approach; the glass roof can be seen from below
– Wrong drop point, lost gear or harm as consequences

A fall through the glass roof is a possible consequence, not the automatic result.

Façade maintenance

STEALTH · RIGGER · HACKER

+ Bypasses the main entrance
+ Tools and climbing gear look plausible
+ Docks at a technical airlock just below the penthouse
– The gondola is building tech and is logged
– Guests or cameras may see it
– A wrong drive command stops or locks it

Gondola route manipulated in advance, maintenance order injected, technician access bought.

THE PLAYERS' OWN IDEA

If the plan is compatible with the established fiction, play it out. Chartered skycab, staged medical emergency, art transport, hijacked delivery drone swarm, unusual magic: good ideas may bypass planned areas completely.

45–70 min STEP 5

The party in the penthouse

The gala is in full swing. Here the runners solve two problems, in any order: Dr. Venn's eye scan and the vault keycard from the event office.

SEE ALSO Plan Level 111: 2D · 3D | Plan Level 112: 2D · 3D | Cheat sheet Combat & opposition | Kade (A) | Kade (B) | Dr. Venn

ATMOSPHERE

Glass, dark wood, living plants, AR sculptures and real art compete for attention. From the open atrium the lights of Seattle show between the clouds. Subtle music lies over conversations of corporate people, collectors, artists and people whose actual work nobody names openly. Service drones carry drinks.

Security observes rather than intimidates. Everything is meant to look expensive, controlled and effortless.

AREAS

Grand salon
LEVEL 111

The social centre. Many guests, good cover in the crowd, but also many eyes.

Exhibition gallery
VENN'S TERRITORY

Dr. Venn spends most of her time here. Pieces are annotated in AR with provenance and value. The collector's lift lies behind it.

Winter garden
QUIET

Slightly apart. A good opportunity for private conversation or an inconspicuous biometric capture.

Service area
KITCHEN · STORAGE · EVENT OFFICE

Staff corridor, storage and the event office with the keycard in the black box. Guests stand out here.

Private study
LEVEL 112

Not part of the event. Behind a flush wooden panel lies the private lift to the vault level.

Glass roof and roof access
EXPOSED

Visible from below. Spectacular but very conspicuous.

DR. VENN AND THE EYE SCAN

The runners decide how to obtain the biometric factor. Important: **Venn does not have the keycard.** Even if the crew wins her over completely, the card remains a problem. First the player describes the action, from that follows the action rating; there is no "you must roll Interface here".

- High-resolution capture of the left eye and preparation of a retinal duplicate.
- Get Venn to look voluntarily into a scanner or optical device.
- Arrange a private viewing of the collection.
- Lure Venn to the access airlock under a pretext.
- Sedate or abduct her: not automatic failure, just far more conspicuous and risky.
- Magic, as far as the specific character is actually capable of it.

Private viewing
THE SOCIAL HIGH ROAD

Venn may register selected guests and escort them to the antechamber. She legitimises the biometric part but cannot open the vault alone: four-eyes principle with a separately stored keycard.

- Recon drones count and identify the registered persons
- Sensors check for unregistered gear
- Drones make sure nobody leaves the group
- Deviations trigger re-authentication or a silent alarm

The advantage is not "no security" but a better starting position: actions against the drones can be **controlled** instead of risky or desperate.

To the airlock under a pretext
DECEPTION

Venn only confirms her factor without believing she is conducting a viewing: an alleged climate fault on a sensitive piece, an automatic security notice, a faulty access attempt by an employee, a fault in the collection area.

- Venn goes to the authentication point and scans
- The door stays shut until the keycard is used
- Venn may stand right next to them while the second factor has to appear
- Waiting too long or contradictory statements make the drones suspicious

A social success does not skip the vault level. It only changes how security classifies the runners at first.

> BIOMETRIC FACTOR: CONFIRMED · PHYSICAL FACTOR: PENDING

THE VAULT KEYCARD AND DORIAN KADE

> **TWO KADES TO CHOOSE FROM**
> Under “Key people” there are two variants: a human with chromed cyberarms and a troll who fits effortlessly into the gala despite horns and tusks. Keycard knowledge, duties and reactions to alert are the same either way.

The card is dark grey, unlabelled and shows a faintly iridescent hologram only when viewed directly. It sits in the event office in a black key box; withdrawal and return are logged. The security architecture deliberately separates biometrics and physical authorisation.

Kade does not carry the card himself but knows exactly where it is and how a legitimate withdrawal works: he or a staff member he designates authorises the release, then it is checked back in. Possible approaches: bypass the box, copy the card, intercept a legitimate withdrawal, deceive Kade, fake an authorisation, or something else entirely.

> **OPTIONAL COMPLICATION**
> For very socially strong groups: a second ork woman with a shaved head and silver tusk caps is on the guest list and can be mistaken for Venn from a distance. Better left out for a beginners’ one-shot.

CONSEQUENCES AT THE PARTY

- A security officer politely asks for identification.
- A guest thinks they recognise a runner.
- Dr. Venn becomes suspicious.
- The keycard is temporarily removed from the event office.
- A bulky equipment crate is to be inspected.
- Alert +1 or +2.

> **IF THE PARTY DRAGS ON**
> Dr. Venn announces she will leave soon (in about twenty minutes). A piece of art is to go back into the vault. Staff begin dismantling. Pick whatever follows logically from what has happened.

45–70 min STEP 6

The vault level · level 110

No living staff, but sensors, airlocks and drones. Do not run the level as a dungeon with ten rooms: four core areas are enough, the magical shell lies over them as an extra layer.

SEE ALSO Plan Level 110: 2D · 3D Cheat sheet Alert, Matrix & payoff Cheat sheet Magic in the tower

Two regular lifts lead down: the **collector’s lift** behind the exhibition rooms and the **private lift** in Veyrath’s study. Both end in the same sequence. A narrow **maintenance shaft** from the service core offers an additional irregular access.

`Lift` `Access airlock` `Sensor corridor` `Vault door` `Collection`

Access airlock

17.1

Both lifts end in the same matte black airlock. A first sensor layer registers movement, weight and unauthorised devices. Venn's presence or a valid registration only decides whether the group is first treated as expected visitors or as intruders.

- Reported head count does not match
- Conspicuous or unregistered gear
- Someone separates from the group
- Silent alarm, door locks behind the crew, cameras focus, additional identity check

Sensor corridor

17.2

Long, surprisingly empty, almost museum-like. Cameras, motion detectors, invisible light barriers, pressure sensors, local RFID and device scans. Not everything has to matter at once; first describe only what the runners perceive.

- A sensor registers a deviation
- A door closes behind the crew
- A drone activates
- Gear is flagged as a foreign device
- Alert rises

Drone node

17.3

A service niche with the local drones and their maintenance ports. **Recon drones**: small, fast, observe and tag. **Guardian drones**: larger, armed, isolate and suppress; non-lethal options, lethal on massive escalation.

- **Routine:** standard patrol, check irregularities
- **Authorised viewing:** escort, count, compare; better position but watched
- **Irregularity:** position themselves between suspects and vault, demand authentication, separate people; weapons only on further escalation

Drones do not roll. Their behaviour runs through the runners' action rolls and consequences. Beating them: Interface, sabotage, rerouting, locking in, precise shots at sensors, melee, spoofing target recognition, distraction, magic, or simply being faster.

The vault door

17.4

Two separate checks: read the keycard, confirm the eye scan within a short time. Order does not matter; the first factor opens a short window for the second. Every attempt is logged; a clean double access opens without alarm.

- Venn does not have the keycard; her presence does not replace the physical factor
- Without one or both factors access remains possible: manipulation, heavy tools, explosives, magic, flashback
- It then gets louder, riskier or slower, not impossible

MAGICAL SHELL OF THE VAULT

The walls of the vault proper are threaded with cultivated living tissue: dark fibre strands like roots or muscle between the layers. It carries a **dual mana barrier** shielding physically and astrally. The tissue reacts to drilling and vibration, small wounds close, on alarm the fibres thicken. Damage is visible: fibres twitch, dark fluid seeps out. Outside the barrier an **astral watcher** may optionally patrol; it only reports and is not a mandatory opponent.

CHANCES FOR MAGE AND ADEPT

- **Assense** reveals mana barrier, watcher, magical traces and conspicuous objects in the collection.
- A mage can study how the barrier opens in a controlled way at the regular doorway and gain an approach of their own.
- An adept notices subtle environmental changes, danger, stress reactions or sensors earlier; with Assense or Astral Warrior they tackle astral problems directly.
- Magical antiques can be told apart from mundane pieces.

CONSEQUENCES ON THE VAULT LEVEL

- A drone gains visual contact.
- An airlock locks.
- A weapon or tool is damaged or lost.
- Security foam fills a section and hampers movement and sight.
- The direct way back is blocked.
- The biometric copy only works partially; an additional step is needed.
- Alert rises sharply.

IF THE LEVEL DRAGS ON

Reduce it to three beats: a sensor problem, a drone confrontation, the vault door. Everything else becomes description or consequence.

climax STEP 7

The vault and the case

Not a bank room full of deposit boxes but the modern hoard of a dragon. The case lies unremarkably among things obviously worth more. This is where the decision Veyrath really cares about is made.

SEE ALSO Plan Level 110: 2D · 3D | Cheat sheet Magic in the tower | Veyrath

VEYRATH'S MODERN DRAGON HOARD

The lights come up slowly: paintings from several centuries, sculptures and archaeological objects, old and modern melee weapons, high-end firearms, jewellery and historical gems, rare printed books, sealed data archives, single pieces of modern cyber- and biotechnology, several magical antiques and things whose value can hardly be judged without expert knowledge. Everything is curated; nothing lies around by chance. The black briefcase rests on a low plinth between far more conspicuous objects.

TEMPTATION

At least one piece is obviously more valuable than the case and surprisingly easy to take: a small casket of historical gems, an ornate magical antique, a compact piece of cybertech. There is **no additional trap** on it. If the players want to take something, let them. The contract merely forbids it, and Veyrath will judge it very precisely later.

THE BRIEFCASE

Exterior
VISIBLE TO ALL

About 45 cm wide, matte black ceramic composite, remarkably old-fashioned: no AR display, no data port, no logo, no radio signal. A single thin ivory line runs almost as a circle over lid and base, broken only at the handle by a finger's width. Handle of dark metal wrapped in worn black leather. Over one latch a pale blue single-use tamper seal.

Matrix
OFFLINE

Transmits nothing, cannot be located via the Matrix. Its safeguards work locally without a radio link. In a vault full of networked, gleaming objects this silence seems almost provocatively plain.

Magical
FAINT AURA

A faint, old magical aura. Not dangerous, triggers nothing, but makes the case stand out among the many objects for astrally perceiving characters.

HIDDEN TAMPER PROTECTION

A small, professionally integrated **explosive charge** sits in the frame. If the case is fully opened without neutralisation, the charge primarily destroys the contents. Anyone holding it in front of them is in serious danger, but it is **not an automatic death trap**: harm, lost gear, an alarm or another consequence make more sense than a sudden character death.

Discoverable on deliberate examination: unusual weight, a second inner frame, fine manufacturing gaps along the lid, a separate shielded circuit, chemical or technical traces. Survey, Study, Engineer or Interface may fit; nothing is prescribed. Neutralising is controlled under calm conditions, far riskier under time pressure with active drones.

Second safeguard: an inconspicuous mechanical tamper indicator inside. Even after perfect defusal and clean closing, Veyrath can later tell that it was opened.

Whoever leaves the case closed as ordered never learns of any of this. It is not a mandatory scene and not a puzzle.

BEHAVIOUR	JUDGEMENT
Not opened	Job fulfilled exactly.
Safeguard found, neutralised, opened anyway	Technically impressive, but a clear order ignored.
Opened carelessly	Charge detonates; contents destroyed, situation escalates.

CONTENTS

A palm-sized, cracked disc of black obsidian. Not worthless, but its real value is not apparent to the runners. Why it matters to Veyrath stays open. He deliberately chose an object whose loss would be real but hardly painful for him; that is why the charge is not a dummy. The contents are not a plot device. The test is whether the crew respects the instruction although they could find out more.

20–35 min incl. reveal STEP 8

The escape

Play it out in detail only if it is interesting or time remains. The alert level decides how much resistance the crew meets.

SEE ALSO Plan Roof: 2D · 3D | Plan Section: 2D | Plan Parking garage: 2D · 3D | Cheat sheet Combat & opposition | Cheat sheet Combat | Kade (A)

Glass elevator
ELEGANT AT LOW ALERT

The crew rides down among unsuspecting guests while the city slides past the glass walls. At higher alert the elevator can be stopped, rerouted or checked.

Freight elevator and garage
PRAGMATIC

A prepared vehicle waits below, one is acquired on the spot, or the crew flees on foot into the lower levels of the complex.

Jump from the roof
SPECTACULAR

Parachutes or wingsuits. Wind, pursuers and lost gear are good consequences without playing out every metre.

Façade maintenance
REUSABLE

The gondola can be used again, manually overridden or serve as a waypoint for the descent.

Skycab extraction
CONTACTS · TECH

An autonomous skycab or small aircraft appears at a permitted or improvised outside position: real booking, fake VIP instruction, takeover, rigger or flashback.

Own idea
ALWAYS ALLOWED

If the group finds a plausible better way, let it work.

CONSEQUENCES DURING THE ESCAPE

- The preferred exit is closed.
- An elevator stops on the wrong floor.
- Gear has to be left behind.
- A drone latches onto the crew.
- The group is split up.
- A jump or flight manoeuvre causes harm or loss of equipment.

WHO SHOWS UP AT FULL ALERT?

Deliberately just a **contracted external police provider** or a contractual response team. Whether that is Knight Errant or Lone Star is your call if you want to check it against a Seattle source. With plenty of time left, start a short response clock; otherwise the next big consequence is the arriving reinforcement.

during the escape STEP 9

The reveal

During or right after the escape, not as a long monologue. No final boss, no new confrontation: solely the assessment of the test.

SEE ALSO Veyrath Johnson (A)

A vast shadow glides over the façade. Wings beat in the rain. For a moment a real dragon flies or climbs at a clear distance beside the fleeing crew, far larger than anything they expected. It does not block their way and makes no move to attack. Then the runners hear its voice directly in their minds:

> *“Call me Veyrath. The tower is mine. The vault is mine. And so is the case you have just stolen.”*

That makes it clear: they did not rob a rival. Veyrath himself sent them into his own vault. Depending on how things went, he adds:

Clean run

“You take what you were given and leave what is not yours. Rare. So you are actually good for something.”

Successful but chaotic

“Not elegant. Not quiet. But you are still alive and the case is with you. That will do for now.”

Lots of violence

“Violence is a tool. Whoever uses the same tool for every problem is no craftsman.”

Extra loot

“I asked you for one object. You decided my property should raise your pay. I will remember that.”

Opened case

“Curiosity is valuable. So is discipline. Tonight you showed me which of the two wins with you.”

Charge neutralised cleanly

“Recognising the safeguard was good work. Having to overcome it was your own decision.”

NO FIGHT

Veyrath stays out of reach, does not threaten the crew and does not block their escape. If the runners shoot at him, he ends the contact and withdraws rather than turning the epilogue into a fight against a dragon.

wrap-up STEP 10

Payoff and assessment

The base pay is 6 nuyen. Veyrath ties the actual payout to the crew's professionalism. The calculator on the left applies the rule.

SEE ALSO Cheat sheet Alert, Matrix & payoff | Johnson (A)

ALERT AT THE END	PAYOUT
Low alert (0–1)	6 nuyen
Medium alert (2–5)	5 nuyen
High alert / lockdown (6)	3 nuyen

Injured or dead guests and staff count **at least as high alert** for the payout. Seriously harming or killing Dr. Venn is additionally a clear breach of contract. Damage to the collection weighs even heavier for Veyrath than harm to people: damaged or additionally stolen pieces draw his marked displeasure and can cut the payout further.

Ideal candidates
FOLLOW-UP JOBS

- Case unopened
- No extra loot, collection undamaged
- Venn unharmed
- Little unnecessary violence
- Problems solved creatively and as a team

Usable but risky
MAYBE

- Job done
- Medium or high alert
- Avoidable attention
- Unnecessary but not catastrophic escalation

Not suitable
NO FURTHER CONTACT

- Case opened deliberately, even expertly
- Contents destroyed by careless opening
- Venn seriously harmed or killed
- Collection damaged or extra loot taken
- Indiscriminate killing despite clear orders

This does not mean the characters were "played wrong". It is this employer's reaction to their decisions. Give the crew room at the payoff to react to the reveal.

OPTIONAL: HEAT PER RITS

For a pure one-shot skip this step. If the crew continues, heat is determined by the normal rules, not copied from the alert clock: 0 heat smooth & quiet, 2 contained, 4 loud & chaotic, 6 wild, plus situational modifiers for high-profile targets or killings. **Alert** is what security knows and does now. **Heat** is the long-term attention afterwards.

throughout the run TOOLS

Alert, consequences and pacing

The alert clock replaces heat during the run. It rises when an action plausibly draws attention and can fall when the fiction allows it.

SEE ALSO Cheat sheet Running rolls | Cheat sheet Alert, Matrix & payoff

ALERT CLOCK · 6 SEGMENTS

Routine
0–1

- Anomalies count as normal event deviations
- Drones patrol on standard patterns
- No search for the runners

Suspicion
2–3

- Cameras compare movements and identities more closely
- Single doors ask for credentials again
- Drones watch conspicuous areas
- Staff are quietly questioned

Active alarm
4–5

- Drones search actively
- Service routes partly closed
- Elevators stopped or rerouted
- Guests kept away from endangered areas
- Identified runners are pursued

Lockdown
6

- Alarm counts as confirmed
- Escape routes locked or controlled
- External security or police provider called
- Room to act remains, but clearly escalation

Suspicion means **no automatic dice penalty**. The changed fiction influences position and effect of coming actions. If an action works directly on the clock, limited / standard / great effect maps to 1 / 2 / 3 segments.

When does alert rise?
A FITTING CONSEQUENCE WHEN …

- a camera sees something
- a sensor is triggered
- a false identity is checked
- a drone sends a warning
- a guest raises the alarm
- a door is forced open
- shots or explosions are audible
- a Matrix intrusion leaves a usable trace

Not every failed roll raises alert. Equally possible: harm, lost gear, worse position, less effect, blocked exit, suspicious Venn, keycard moved elsewhere, a drone appears, group split up.

Can alert fall?
TUG-OF-WAR CLOCK

- A runner credibly explains to a guard why the deviation was harmless
- A camera sequence is replaced with older footage
- A triggered sensor is disguised as a fault
- A drone is intercepted before it reports
- A manipulated door log looks like maintenance
- A party incident explains noise or movement

Nobody says “I roll to lower alert”. First it must be clear what the character does in the world. On success alert drops according to effect, or an imminent rise is prevented.

NO HACKER REQUIRED

A hacker has many opportunities to prevent alert but no exclusive right to it. Social: redirect suspicion, keep staff busy. Deception: identity or work order. Physical: disable a sensor or drone before it transmits. Precision: destroy optics and weapon modules. Tech: cables, doors, local controls. Magic: perception or movement. Mobility: leave the area before the search closes in. Repeated hacks do not automatically get harder, only when the fiction gives a reason: a countermeasure is running, a trace has begun, a system was isolated.

SCENARIO-SPECIFIC DRAGON’S DEALS

⚖ The invitation is genuine. But someone at the party recognises your alias.

⚖ You get the perfect biometric scan. Dr. Venn will remember your face very precisely later.

⚖ The drone goes offline at once. Its last data burst, however, has already been sent.

⚖ The maintenance gondola takes you exactly to the target. Then it locks itself outside and is no longer available for the escape.

⚖ You reach the case without further resistance. In return the vault door closes behind you.

SPOTLIGHT FOR THE PLAYBOOKS

PLAYBOOK	TYPICAL CHANCES TO SHINE
Face	Invitation, contacts, a serious collector role, keeping Venn busy, defusing suspicion socially
Hacker	Guest lists, cameras, elevators, access logs, drones, building tech
Muscle	Protecting the group, heavy gear, non-lethal takedowns, forced emergency routes, drones in melee
Punk	Façade infiltration, parkour, distraction, sabotage, chaotic improvisation and escape
Rigger	Pilot for drop or escape, maintenance gondola, building drones, vehicles, remote control
Snake	Staff roles, disguise, deception, keycard theft, manipulating Venn
Trigger	Overwatch, spotting danger early, precisely disabling drone components, securing the exit
Adept	Depending on the way: perception, danger sense, mobility, physical infiltration; with fitting abilities astral problems
Mage	Assense the mana barrier and watcher, magical traces, telling magical objects apart, own workarounds
Techno	Influencing signals and networked systems emergently, manipulating drones or building tech, spotting anomalies

The run is not a character quiz. Nobody gets a room “just for their class”. The actions on the sheet matter more than the label.

PACING

Planning too long?

- Which plan are you using?
- What is the detail?
- Which load do you choose?
- Then engagement roll and cut to the action.

Plenty of time left?

- Play the escape in more detail
- Let a cut-off runner look for an alternative route
- Response clock after full alert
- Give the crew room at the payoff to react to the reveal

for printing APPENDIX

Quick reference

Everything important at a glance when there is no time to flip pages at the table.

SEE ALSO Cheat sheet Core rules · Cheat sheet Which action?

The job

- **Steal:** the black case from the vault, unopened
- **Hidden safeguard:** charge primarily destroys the contents on unauthorised opening; discoverable and defusable
- **Tamper indicator:** opening stays provable even after defusal
- **Do not steal:** anything else · **Do not harm:** Dr. Venn · **Avoid:** deaths
- **Payoff:** 6 nuyen at low alert, 5 at medium, 3 at high; harm to people at least as high

Access factors

- Vault keycard in the black box in the event office (service area)
- Dr. Venn's eye scan: left, amber, natural eye
- Without one or both factors access remains possible, but louder, riskier, slower

Penthouse 111/112

- Grand salon · exhibition gallery · winter garden
- Service area with event office
- Collector's lift behind the exhibition rooms
- Private study with private lift
- Glass roof and roof access

Vault level 110

- Shared access airlock
- Sensor corridor
- Drone node: recon and guardians
- Vault door: keycard + eye scan, any order
- Living vault shell with dual mana barrier, optional astral watcher
- Modern dragon hoard with temptation

Alert clock ○○○○○○

- **0–1** routine
- **2–3** suspicion
- **4–5** active alarm
- **6** lockdown + external response

NPCs

- **Mr. Johnson:** Veyrath's professional fixer
- **Dr. Amara Venn:** ork curator, left eye = biometrics, has no keycard
- **Dorian Kade:** head of security, cyberarms, knows storage and release of the keycard
- **Veyrath:** ambitious young dragon, owner and employer, tests the crew, never fights

The truth

- Veyrath owns penthouse, vault, collection and case and commissioned the break-in into his own vault
- No rival dragon
- The gala deliberately creates a realistic window
- Tested: discipline, creativity, teamwork and control of escalation

Dice

- **6** success · **4/5** with consequence · **1–3** bad · several 6s critical
- Position: controlled / risky / desperate · effect: limited / standard / great
- 2 edge push, 1 edge assist, resistance costs edge
- Flashback 0–2 edge depending on effort

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